

STARTUP ZONE

Crux LX: A Unified Communications Platform For Small And Medium Businesses



Crux LX

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Communication is an integral part of business operations. At present, not only large businesses and enterprises but, small and medium-scale businesses (SMBs) serve from geographically-distributed regions, requiring investments in digital communication methods. To bring to them a cost-effective, user-friendly and easy-to-maintain connectivity solution, startup Crux Labs offers Crux LX.

Problems that Crux LX addresses

Rohit Gupta, founder of Singapore-based Crux Labs, noticed the lack of a scalable and cost-effective on-premise connectivity solution for SMBs. Solutions that exist were majorly analogue-based, requiring hardwiring. These were difficult to install and cumbersome

to maintain. Wiring and installation required high charges for cables and service. A bigger problem came when users had to shift base, which required them to follow the whole Herculean process all over again. Digital solutions, on the other hand, are expensive.

Gupta says, "Big enterprises have perks like work-from-home or geographically-distributed and connected workforces. They have made investments in communication technologies accordingly. But, that level of investment is difficult for SMBs."

While connecting with some businesses who belonged to their target customer category—companies with fewer than 100 employees—Gupta realised that the existing challenges were multifold. He also found that private branch exchange (PBX) vendors offer analogue-based solutions from big brands, starting at about ₹ 60,000

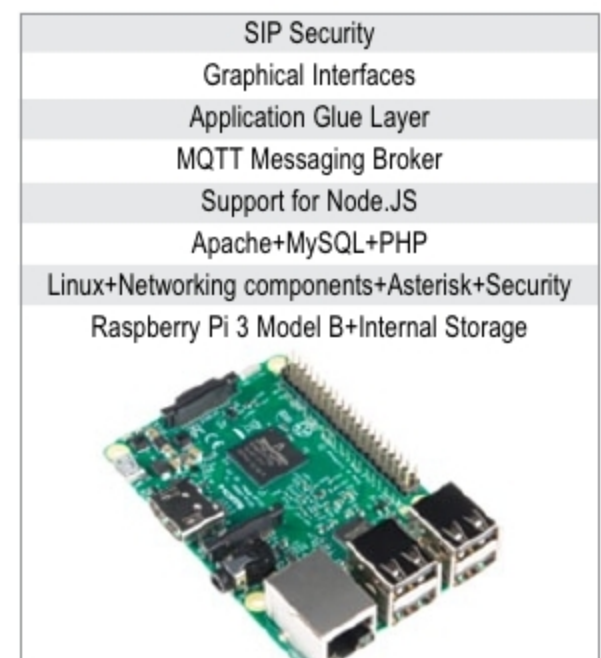
to ₹ 65,000 and higher for more than 50 users. When asked for IP-based digital solutions, these vendors quote about SG\$ 8000 to SG\$ 10,000 (₹ 403,000 to ₹ 503,000 approximately)—price range that does not match the economies of scale for SMBs.

In addition, these solutions lack scalability and simplicity. Most cater to a limited number of users (30 to 50), which cannot be expanded further. Therefore as businesses grow, they may have to invest in whole new setups once again.

Gupta mentions that the best alternatives so far—cloud-based IP communication solutions—have their own set of challenges. He explains, "Although these solutions do not require any upfront capital, subscription rates draw an expense almost equivalent to expensive on-premise IP-based solutions. Within a span of two to three years, the cost point becomes similar, failing to serve the purpose for SMBs." Crux Labs wanted to address all these issues at once.

Crux LX architecture

Most of today's connectivity, especially in tier 1 cities, runs through fibre cables, eventually channelling voice-based signals over the telephone and network data over the router. Crux team wanted to create a platform that



Crux LX stacks and components